The current narrative on China's historic frontiers builds on a thesis put forward as far back as 1981 by the Chinese scholar Tan Qixiang in his paper, 'Historical China and China's Dynastic Frontiers'. Tan argues:

> How do we handle the question of historical China? We take the territory of the Qing dynasty after its complete unification and prior to the encroachment of imperialism on China, specifically China's territory from the 1750s to the 1840s, the period preceding the Opium Wars, as the historical sphere of China. What is termed historical China is this sphere. Whether it is a question of centuries or millennia, the nationalities active within this sphere are considered to be China's historical regimes. This is the main current of the historical development of the Chinese people. [8]

This implies that even if there were periods in Chinese history when some nationalities included in this historic sphere ran independent kingdoms or polities, such polities would be considered Chinese regimes. In this interpretation, Tibet was part of China since ancient times.

What was presaged in this academic paper became the basis for the next step in the Chinese historical narrative-building and is reflected in an interview given by Sun Yong, a senior official of China's Tibetan Academy of Social Sciences, to the *People's Daily* in February 2009. Applying Tan Qixiang's thesis to Tibet, Sun had this to say:

> When we say today that Tibet has been a part of China 'since ancient times' it is an historical fact. To say since ancient times is not the same as saying 'since the Yuan dynasty'; it is to say 'since human activity began' . . . it is also not to say 'the regime in Tibet since ancient times has always been a part of the area effectively governed by political authority from the Central Plains or the political authority of the Central Government'. [9]

In other words, even if there were periods when Tibet was ruled by local political entities or fell outside the authority of a central Chinese government, it would still be part of the flow of China's history. Sun Yong argues that to accept that there was a period – before the Yuan dynasty, for example – when Tibet was not part of the motherland, this did not 'accord with the historical fact of the evolutionary process of China's historical inseparability'.

These later narratives have been covered in a paper by Elliot Sperling in the March 2009 issue of the academic journal *Chinese Perspectives* , entitled 'The Deadlock in Tibet'. The author describes these Chinese assertions as 'mind boggling'. [10] In recent years expansive Chinese